

mouse pointer changing to something else. Of course, if you went to one of those “1000 cursors free!” sites and downloaded and installed cursors, then you’re infected by spyware anyway.

13. Icons on the desktop that you didn’t place are again a giveaway symptom.

14. If you just installed a program—successfully—and it doesn’t work properly, or if its icons have vanished, don’t reinstall it! There’s no time to waste—quickly do a scan.

15. Now this could also be an indicator of spyware, but when you notice that your modem is doing a lot of activity on its own—both sending and receiving—or if your hard disk is performing more activity than you’d expect, like chattering away when you’re not even working on anything, it could be a sign of viral infection.

3.2 Enter The Warriors

It’s time to take a look at your trusty system-tray defenders, the anti-viruses themselves. We did say in the previous section that you’ll need to scan your computer if you noticed any of the symptoms we described, but now the question is, what anti-virus to choose?

There are two aspects to an anti-virus—one is its resident protection feature, that is, the feature by which it constantly monitors your system for suspicious activity. The other is the option whereby you scan areas of your computer for infection. All the anti-viruses we’ll be talking about have both these.

In the case of anti-spyware scans, you can run a scan using one program and then repeat it using the other, so each catches what the other missed. But unfortunately, you can’t have two resident anti-viruses: they’ll conflict with each other. As a result, you’ll have to decide upon one. The following test will help you do so: it’s